Other regional forces, too, have to worry about what the rise of Modi means for their future. Mamata Banerjee in Bengal, for example, has now realized that the BJP is an emerging force in the state's politics and has even hinted, quite tellingly, at a reach-out to the left. Mulayam Singh may have to shift gears as well—the 2014 elections have shown that his brazen attempts at minority appeasement are bound to invite a political backlash. Mayawati may never ally with Mulayam, but she, too, has to move beyond the politics of fake empowerment—statues are not a substitute for development. In Maharashtra, Sharad Pawar is making a big mistake if he thinks reservations for the politically influential Marathas will be a game changer—every time you give reservations to one group, you end up alienating many others. Perhaps the only regional leaders who will feel secure are Naveen Patnaik and Jayalalithaa. The Modi tsunami has stayed away from the Odisha and Tamil Nadu coastline.

Arvind Kejriwal, too, has been humbled by the 2014 election verdict. The politician who insisted that the AAP would fight in more than 400 seats across the country is now terrified of even contesting the Haryana elections. His sole aim, he says, is rebuilding his base in Delhi. It seems a rather strange U-turn for a politician who at the start of 2014 thought he could walk on water. At least Kejriwal has shown some spunk, though—when the Modi government completed forty-nine days, he put up posters across Delhi comparing his achievements with that of the prime minister. If only the Congress and Rahul could show similar fight, politics in the country may become a little less one-sided.

That nothing is permanent in politics is best exemplified by the left's pitiable condition. In the 2004 elections, they held the balance of power at the Centre and helped shape the first UPA government. Ten years later, they have been reduced to marginal players—intellectual hubris and an unwillingness to adapt to a changing India have made the left parties almost irrelevant to the national discourse.

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